

Who Is Flying the Plane?

On the night of 1 June 2009, somewhere over the Atlantic, three small tubes on the nose of an Airbus A330 iced over.

That's it. That's the whole malfunction. The pitot tubes couldn't read airspeed, so the autopilot did the honest thing: it switched itself off and handed the aeroplane back to the men who were being paid to fly it.

They had it for four minutes. In that time, Air France 447 climbed, stalled, and fell thirty-eight thousand feet into the sea. Two hundred and twenty-eight people died. The ice cleared within a minute. The machine was fine.

What had degraded was the pilots.

This is the shape of the thing I want to talk about. Not the horror-movie version where the machine turns on us. The quieter one, where the machine works perfectly, hands us back the controls, and we discover we've forgotten how.

Cognitive debt

Last June, researchers at the MIT Media Lab wired up fifty-four people and had them write essays — some with ChatGPT, some with a search engine, some with nothing but their own heads. The brain-only group lit up: wide, distributed neural networks. The ChatGPT group showed the weakest connectivity of the three, remembered less of what they'd "written," and reported little sense of ownership over it. By the third session, many were simply pasting the prompt in and pasting the answer out. Two English teachers, not told which was which, described those essays with a single word: *soulless*.

The authors call it **cognitive debt**. I like that phrase because debt is not a wound. It's a deal. You get something now and pay later, and the paying-later feels, at the moment of borrowing, like an abstraction.

It's one preprint, fifty-four people, one task. Don't build a religion on it. But it sits on top of something much older and much better established.

Back in 2015, Fisher, Goddu and Keil ran nine experiments at Yale and found that people who looked something up online afterwards rated their *own internal* understanding as higher — not their access to information, their personal knowledge. Ask them how a zipper works and they feel they know. They don't. They know where to look. The mind, it turns out, is very bad at telling the difference between a thing it knows and a thing it can reach.

Here is the part that should make the hair stand up: the effect showed up even when the search *failed*.

We are not becoming stupider. We are becoming stupider **while feeling smarter**, which is a categorically worse position, because the first is a problem and the second is a problem that hides.

The friction was the point

Ask any teacher what makes something stick and you'll get the same answer: struggle. Robert Bjork spent a career on this and gave it a name — *desirable difficulties*. Material that comes easily is forgotten easily. Retrieval, effort, the humiliating pause where you can't remember and have to reconstruct — that pause is not an obstacle to learning. **That pause is the learning.**

Now notice what every product in your life is engineered to do.

Eliminate the pause.

This is why "AI makes me more productive" and "AI is degrading me" are not contradictory claims. They're the same claim. The tool removes friction. The friction was the mechanism. You are getting exactly what you paid for, and the price is coming out of an account you can't see.

The assessment mindset

It gets stranger when it reaches love.

By 2017, meeting online had become the single most common way American couples found each other. Not a fringe. The default. And in a long review of the psychological evidence, Eli Finkel and his colleagues put their finger on the mechanism that nobody wants to hear: browsing profiles induces an **assessment mindset**. You're not meeting a person. You're evaluating inventory. Height, income, jawline, filter. And a mind in assessment mode does something predictable — it keeps assessing. Commitment starts to feel like a failure to optimise.

There is always a better option. There is *always* a better option, because the deck is infinite by design. So we swipe with the diligence of a fund manager, and we end up lonely with excellent taste.

Byung-Chul Han says something harder. Love, he argues, requires *the Other* — someone genuinely outside you, who can wound you, who cannot be predicted. What the algorithm delivers instead is the Same: matched to your preferences, filtered to your revealed tastes, pre-approved. A mirror with a face. And you cannot fall in love with a mirror. You can only fall into it.

The exhibited self

"The present age is essentially a sensible age, devoid of passion... it changes the expression of strength into a feat of dialectics."

Kierkegaard. 1846. He was complaining about *newspapers*. He watched a public form — a phantom, he called it, a crowd that is nobody — and he watched people begin to perform for it instead of living, gossiping about action rather than acting. He predicted the timeline with a hundred and seventy years to spare, and the only thing he got wrong was the scale.

Sartre named the sensation: *the Look*. The moment you realise you are being seen, you stop being a subject and become an object — a thing with a shape, seen from outside. He thought this happened occasionally, in doorways, through keyholes.

We built a machine that does it continuously, and we hold it eight inches from our faces.

But here's the fact I'd put in bold if I only had one. In 2018, economists paid roughly 2,700 people to deactivate Facebook for four weeks. First, they asked what it was worth: most wanted around a hundred dollars to give it up for a month. The ones who actually quit came out the other side with *higher* life satisfaction, more time with family, less political polarisation — and afterwards, they used Facebook less and valued it lower than before.

Read that again. **They didn't know what it was worth until it was gone, and it was worth less than they thought.** We are not addicted to something wonderful. We are addicted to something we systematically overprice, and the overpricing is not a rumour, it's measured. Herbert Simon saw it coming in 1971: information is not the scarce thing. Attention is. A wealth of one creates a poverty of the other.

The honest part

Now the part the doom-merchants leave out, because it's inconvenient and I'd rather be useful than dramatic.

The claim that phones caused a mental-health collapse is *contested*. Serious researchers — Candice Odgers among them — have pointed out that most of the evidence is correlational, the effect sizes are small, and the causal story is far weaker than the bestseller lists suggest. It might be true. It isn't established.

I don't think it matters much, because the argument doesn't need it. The case isn't that these tools make us *ill*. The case is that they make us **thin**.

Thin: capable of retrieving anything and understanding nothing. Fluent and unoriginal. Surrounded and unaccompanied. Endlessly assessing, never choosing. Very well informed

about a world we are no longer in.

The controls

I'm not going to tell you to delete anything. Detoxes are a genre, and genres are lies with a marketing budget.

I'll tell you what the pilots needed, which is the only thing that has ever worked: **hours on the stick**. Not fewer machines. More flying.

So: think a thought all the way through before you ask anything to help you. Sit in the pause. Let the name you're groping for stay lost for an hour — it will come back, and when it does it will be *yours*. Read the long thing. Meet the person who is not your type. Be bad at something in public, unassisted, where it costs you.

Simone Weil said attention, absolutely unmixed, is the rarest and purest form of generosity. She meant it as an ethic. It has become, without anybody voting on it, a form of resistance.

The autopilot is very good now. It will be better next year.

Somebody has to remember how to fly.